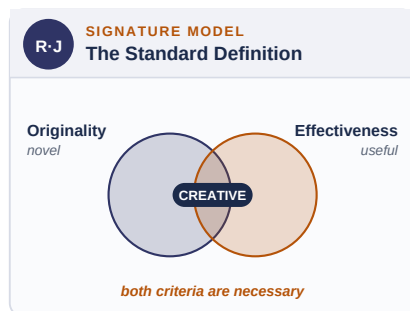


Mark A. Runco & Garrett J. Jaeger

The Standard Definition of Creativity — Originality × Effectiveness

Creativity researchers · Southern Oregon University / Torrance Center legacy



“Originality is vital for creativity but is not sufficient.”

“Creative ideas are both original and effective.”

1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

Everyone uses the word 'creativity', but few can define it. Runco and Jaeger did the field a service by pinning down the definition almost all researchers now share — originality plus effectiveness — and tracing where it came from. Every other creativity tool rests on this baseline.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Mark Runco is a leading creativity scholar, long-time editor of the *Creativity Research Journal* and author of the field's standard textbook. Garrett Jaeger is a developmental researcher of creative cognition. Their 2012 paper consolidated a century of scattered definitions.

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
The Standard Definition	Creativity = originality (novelty) + effectiveness (usefulness)
Originality criterion	The idea must be novel, surprising or uncommon
Effectiveness criterion	The idea must be useful, fit or valuable to the task
Bipartite structure	Both criteria are necessary; neither alone suffices
Definitional lineage	Traced to Stein (1953), Barron, and mid-century scholars

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Use both criteria as a gate: is the idea novel AND useful?
- Reject 'novel but useless' and 'useful but derivative' as non-creative
- Apply the definition to set clear evaluation criteria for ideas
- Distinguish creativity (ideas) from innovation (implementation)
- Anchor teaching and assessment on a shared, defensible definition

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Definition is deliberately minimal — says little about process
- 'Effectiveness' is context-dependent and hard to measure
- Threshold for 'original' varies by domain and observer
- Says nothing about how creativity is produced
- Debate continues over adding 'surprise' as a third criterion

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- The most-cited modern definition of creativity
- Standard reference in creativity research and teaching
- Gives educators a defensible assessment baseline
- Underpins the novelty/usefulness logic of ideation tools
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Unit 1 definition of creativity

SELECTED WORKS

THE STANDARD DEFINITION OF CREATIVITY <i>Creativity Research Journal</i> RUNCO & JAEGER · 2012	CREATIVITY: THEORIES & THEMES <i>Research, Development, Practice</i> RUNCO · 2014	CREATIVITY RESEARCH JOURNAL <i>Editor (long-serving)</i> RUNCO · ongoing	THE CREATIVITY RESEARCH HANDBOOK <i>Hampton Press</i> RUNCO (ed.) · 1997
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REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

- Runco, M.A. and Jaeger, G.J. (2012) 'The Standard Definition of Creativity', *Creativity Research Journal*, 24(1), pp. 92–96.
- Runco, M.A. (2014) *Creativity: Theories and Themes*. 2nd edn. San Diego: Academic Press.